I definitely had a temper on me, and hated failure. One day Dad came home with a video camera. Naturally enough, we were his cinematic guinea pigs. I went into bat, pads and helmet on, did the Robin Smith crouch and the exaggerated knee jiggling, and Adrian got me out first ball. That was it. Tears everywhere.

Dad found my meltdown hilarious, and filmed me sitting behind a tree, screaming. I'm not entirely sure I'm over it to this day. At least I was forced to bowl, against my will. In retrospect that was a valuable test of character. You don't often see the bigger picture when you're ten, and aware of people saying you have real talent.

I played for the Under-11s at eight, scored 50 for the Maldon thirds when I was eleven. I was too young to regard failure to score runs as an educational experience; perspective comes later, when you realize there will be days when you dominate the bowler, and days when he dominates you. The important thing was that I played a lot of cricket because I wanted to, rather than being made to.

My technique had to be natural, since we rarely had formal coaching. I never saw myself bat until I was thirteen, when I realized the local paper, which had prematurely praised me as the new David Gower, might have gone a little over the top. I lacked his fluency and languor. At best, I was crablike but effective.

I was aware of a climate of expectation, but it didn't become oppressive because it wasn't generated by my parents. They cared, of course, but they never pushed me. They seemed to trust the self-reliance I had acquired as a boarder. It wasn't quite sink or swim, but they didn't exactly rush for a lifebelt if I got into deep water.

My own perspective of parenthood tells me such measured detachment must be healthy. On the schools circuit there have been more naturally gifted players emerge and break records, only to regress in senior cricket, where they seemed worn down by the responsibility of meeting parental demands. If my son Jack wants to play cricket in the future that's fine, but I will never force the game on him or renew my competitive instincts through him.

All you can do is allow a young player to be himself. There is a danger, across sport, of academy players becoming homogenized. They are treated like a protected species, nurtured in three-day England training camps at the age of thirteen. Talent becomes a barrier to a normal life; a promising